MASTERCLASS 1 · 20 NOVEMBER 2026

The heart of the business.

Why operations decides whether a founder's ideas ever happen.

Format	Live masterclass, up to 90 minutes including questions
Audience	Founders House members. No course needed beforehand
Presenter	Mila Milićević · NexaStrategic
Deck	25 slides, linked in Nexa OS

DRAFT · PLAN AND SCRIPT

1. Scope

The one idea. Every business has a brain (the founder), a body (what customers see) and a heart (operations), which moves decisions, money, information and people to every part, on a rhythm. A brilliant brain can't keep a body alive on its own. When the heart isn't set, everything else is a mess.

What founders leave with. They can explain in plain words what operations does, recognise which of four failure conditions their business has, and run a four-question heart check on their own business that week.

In scope	Out of scope
What operations is *for*: the heart and what it moves	What operations is *made of*: the eight panels (that's OF101)
Four ways the heart fails, with real, anonymised stories	How to fix each panel: process, contracts, bookkeeping and so on
Why founders underestimate it	Tools or software recommendations
A live heart check on one real decision	Legal, tax or financial advice
Four questions to take away	Statistics or research claims

How it fits with the course. Different but complementary. The course teaches what operations is made of: the ball and its eight panels. The masterclass explains what it does and why it matters: the heart. The ball appears on one slide only, so the two images don't compete. It ends by pointing into OF101.

The four failure conditions

Condition	What it feels like	Signs	Heart-check question
Blockage	Everything waits for you	Approvals queue up · the team asks before acting · holidays stall the business	What's waiting on me right now?
No rhythm	Nothing happens on a beat	Numbers checked when there's a worry · renewals found when they lapse	When did we last check it properly?
A weak pump	The money can't reach where it's needed	Profitable but short of cash · paid in 60 days, paying in 14	What cash will we have in two months?
The sudden event	It's fine, until it isn't	A key person leaves · a big client goes · a contract surprises you	Who, if gone tomorrow, stops us?

Run sheet

Time	Part	Slides	Goal
0–10	1. The picture	1–8	Give them a new way to see operations
10–30	2. What failure looks like	9–13	Make them recognise their own business
30–40	3. Why it's underestimated	14–16	Explain why they haven't fixed it yet, without blame
40–65	4. Live case	17–20	Show the check working on a real decision
65–75	5. This week	21–24	Turn it into action on their own business
75–90	6. Questions	25	Open discussion

2. Why this topic

I looked at how operations masterclasses for founders are currently pitched. Almost all of them sell the same promise: **get the founder out of the way**. Some examples:

Who	Angle
UCLA Anderson, "The Founder Bottleneck: Scaling Without Burning Out"	The founder as bottleneck
TUM Venture Labs, "Scale Yourself to Scale Your Company"	Founder capacity and delegation
Indy Chamber masterclass, March 2026	Standardised systems and smart delegation
Operations Nation, "Do I even need ops yet?"	A panel including a fractional COO, on when to invest
Schulich, Masterclass Certificate in Venture Operations	A multi-week certificate programme
Sirris Scaleup Masterclass	Scale-up management programme
EOS, "Visionary vs Integrator"	The best-known framework: the founder needs a second person who makes the business run
The AI Edge Masterclass, London	The newer wave: AI in operations

The gap. I found almost nothing that starts by explaining what operations is *for*. The closest is Allison Pickens' piece on why operations is the core of a company, which is a podcast and essay, not a masterclass. Your heart idea fills that gap, and it doesn't depend on hiring an integrator: it works for a five-person business as well as a fifty-person one.

Why it suits this room. Most founders won't have started the course by 20 November, so the masterclass has to stand alone and lead into OF101. The brain–heart–body picture needs no background. It also travels: it works as an Elevate LinkedIn Live, a keynote or a carousel without rewriting.

> **Caveat.** I saw most of these as search listings and summaries. The luma.com and UCLA pages were blocked by my session's network settings, so I haven't read their full agendas. The links are at the end if you want to check any of them.

3. Slide by slide

For each slide: what's on it, the **message** (the one thing it says), the **goal** (what it should do to the room), and a script. The script is a starting point to say in your own words, not to read out. *Italics are stage directions.*

Part 1 · The picture (10 minutes)

1 COVER

The heart of the business. Why operations decides whether your ideas ever happen.

Message This is about whether your ideas actually happen, not about admin.

Goal Reframe operations before you've said anything. Set up the takeaway.

> Thank you for coming. Tonight isn't about admin, and it isn't about systems. It's about why some founders' ideas happen and others' don't, and the part of the business that decides that. Keep a pen handy: by the end you'll have four questions to run on your own business this week.

2 BRAIN

Every business has a brain. You.

Message You, the founder, are the brain: ideas, decisions, direction.

Goal Start with something they're proud of. Build the metaphor one piece at a time.

> Every business has a brain. In a founder-led business, that's you. It's where the ideas come from, where the big decisions get made, where the direction is set. Most founders are very good at this part. It's the reason the business exists.

3 BODY

And a body. What customers see.

Message The body is the product, the service and the brand: where attention goes.

Goal Name where founders put their energy and money first.

> And every business has a body: everything customers see and touch. The product, the service, the people they speak to, the brand. This is where most of the attention goes, and most of the early hiring.

4 QUESTION

What connects them?

Message Something has to turn decisions into what customers experience.

Goal Get the room talking early. Let them find the gap before you name it.

> So here's my question. What connects the two? How does a decision you make on a Monday become something a customer experiences on a Friday? *Pause. Take two or three answers.*

5

HEART

The heart. Operations.

Message Operations isn't the back office. It's the heart.

Goal The reveal. Replace "boring admin" with something vital.

> The heart. Operations. Most people think of operations as the back office, the admin, the boring bit. I think of it as the heart: it moves what the business needs to every part of it, on a steady rhythm. When it works, you don't notice it. When it doesn't, everything else starts to fail.

6

WHAT IT MOVES

Decisions · Money · Information · People.

Message The heart moves four things, to every part, on a rhythm.

Goal Make "operations" concrete without listing departments.

> Four things flow through a business. Decisions: who can decide what, and how a decision reaches the people who act on it. Money: in, out, and to where it's needed, in time. Information: what's happening, what's been promised, what's at risk. People: the right person, with the time and the authority, in the right place. Operations moves all four, steadily, everywhere.

7

DIAGRAM

Brain → heart → body.

Message The brain decides, the body delivers, the heart turns one into the other, in both directions.

Goal One image they'll remember and redraw.

> So here's the whole picture. The brain decides. The body delivers. The heart turns one into the other. Without it, your decisions don't reliably reach the people who have to act on them, and what's happening with customers doesn't reliably reach you.

8

STATEMENT

A brilliant brain can't keep a body alive on its own.

Message You can't be the heart as well as the brain. Not for long.

Goal The thesis of the session. Let it land in silence.

> A brilliant brain can't keep a body alive on its own. *Pause.* Lots of founders try. They become the heart: every decision, every payment, every bit of information goes through them. And it works, for a while. Then the business grows past what one person can pump.

Part 2 · What failure looks like (20 minutes)

9

SECTION

Four conditions. You'll recognise at least one.

Message There are four ways the heart fails.

Goal Make them listen for themselves, not for other people.

> There are four ways the heart fails. As I go through them, I want you to note which one you recognise in your own business. Be honest; nobody's checking.

10 BLOCKAGE

Everything waits for you.

Message When everything passes through one point, the business stops when that point does.

Goal Recognition: “that’s me”. The most common one, so it goes first.

> The first is blockage. The heart can’t pump because everything has to pass through one point, and that point is usually you. Approvals queue up. The team asks before acting. You go on holiday and the business holds its breath. *[Your story: one real, anonymised example.] Fallback (fictional): a founder who signs off every quote goes to a three-day conference; nothing gets quoted and two leads go elsewhere.* Hands up if you’ve had a week where work stopped because you weren’t there.

11 NO RHYTHM

Nothing happens on a beat.

Message Without a regular beat, things only get attention when they go wrong.

Goal Show that busy isn’t the same as regular.

> The second is no rhythm. A heart works because it beats regularly. A business needs a beat too: a weekly look at the numbers, a monthly review, a calendar for renewals and deadlines. Without one, you only look at things when you’re worried. *[Your story.] Fallback (fictional): a team finds out their insurance lapsed only when they need to claim.* Hands up if you look at your numbers on a fixed day every week.

12 WEAK PUMP

The money can’t reach where it’s needed.

Message Profit isn’t cash. Growth can make the gap worse.

Goal The most dangerous condition, and the most often missed. Make it feel real.

> The third is a weak pump. On paper the business makes money, but the cash doesn’t arrive where and when it’s needed. Customers pay you in 60 days; you pay staff and suppliers in 14. Those numbers are just an example. And every new piece of work widens the gap. *[Your story.] Fallback (fictional): a profitable agency can’t make payroll because three clients pay late in the same month.* Hands up if you know what cash you’ll have in two months.

13 SUDDEN EVENT

It’s fine, until it isn’t.

Message Too much hangs on one person, one client or one document.

Goal Make the hidden risk visible before it happens to them.

> The fourth is the sudden event. Everything seems fine, then one thing happens and the business struggles to cope: a key person leaves, a big client goes, a contract says something you didn’t know. It’s usually because too much depended on one thing. *[Your story.] Fallback (fictional): the one person who ran operations leaves, and nobody else has the passwords or knows when the renewals are due.* If your most important person left tomorrow, who would know what they know?

Part 3 · Why it's underestimated (10 minutes)

14 SECTION

Why it's underestimated.

Message If it matters this much, why is it left until it breaks?

Goal Move from guilt to understanding.

> So if the heart matters this much, why do so many of us leave it until something breaks? It's not because founders are careless. There are three reasons.

15 THREE REASONS

Nobody sees it working · body first · cut into pieces.

Message It's invisible when it works, it's hired for last, and when it is invested in it gets split up.

Goal Give them language for why it happened, without blame.

> One: when operations works, nobody sees it. Nobody thanks you for the invoice that went out on time or the renewal that didn't lapse. Two: founders usually hire for the body first, because that's where the revenue is. That's a common pattern, not a rule, and early on it makes sense. But it leaves the heart to the founder. Three: when businesses do invest in operations, they often cut it into pieces.

16 THE BALL

Legal ops. Fin ops. Rev ops. Each team sees one colour.

Message Operations is one thing. Split it up and nobody sees the whole.

Goal The one link to the course. Plant the ball, don't teach it.

> I think of operations as a beach ball. Process, people, money, legal, compliance, governance, risk: different colours, one ball. As businesses grow, they cut it up into legal ops, finance ops, rev ops. Each team sees only its own colour, and nobody sees the whole ball. That's what the course is about, starting with OF101. Tonight, just hold on to this: it's one heart, not four.

Part 4 · Live case (25 minutes)

17 SECTION

Let's check a heart. One real decision, from the room.

Message This works on real decisions, right now.

Goal Switch from listening to doing. Get a volunteer.

> Let's try it on something real. Is anyone facing a decision at the moment: a hire, a new client, a new market, a new product? You can keep it anonymous. *If nobody volunteers within a minute, go to Sam on slide 19.*

18 HEART CHECK

Where does it get stuck? When do we look? Can the money reach it? What stops it overnight?

Message The four conditions become four questions you can ask of any decision.

Goal Give them the tool and let the room use it.

> The four conditions become four questions. Blockage: where will this get stuck, and who will it wait for? Rhythm: when will we look at how it's going, on purpose? Pump: can the money reach it in time? Sudden event: what one person, client or document could stop it overnight? *Let the room do most of the asking.* The point isn't to say no to the decision. It's to find what the heart needs so the decision can work.

19
SAM

Sam wants to open in a second city. A 12-person events agency.

Message A good idea that the heart can't yet carry.

Goal A backup case that's familiar enough for anyone to work on. Fictional.

> This is Sam, who's fictional. Sam runs a 12-person events agency. Demand is strong in another city, and Sam wants to open there next year. Run the heart check: what would you ask? *Take answers before the next slide.*

20
SAM'S CHECK

Every quote goes through Sam · cash checked on Fridays · deposits up front, paid 30 days after · one producer holds every venue.

Message The answer is "yes, once the heart can carry it", not "no".

Goal Show the check leads to specific fixes, not fear.

> Here's what I'd find. Every quote and supplier contract goes through Sam, so a second city doubles the queue. Nobody looks at the numbers weekly; Sam checks the bank on Fridays. Venues want deposits up front and clients pay 30 days after the event, so a second city doubles the cash tied up. And one producer holds every venue relationship. So can Sam open? Yes, once there's a sign-off limit so the team can quote, a weekly cash view, better deposit or payment terms, and a second person on venues.

Part 5 · This week (10 minutes)

21
SECTION

Check your own heart. Four questions for this week.

Message Now do it on your own business.

Goal Bring it home.

> Now your own business. Four questions, one for each condition. I want you to write your answers before you leave.

22
THIS WEEK

What's waiting on me? When did we last check? What cash in two months? Who, if gone tomorrow, stops us?

Message Four questions you can answer in ten minutes, and should.

Goal The takeaway. Everyone writes something down.

> One: what is waiting on me right now? Write the list. Two: when did we last check how things are going, properly and on purpose? If you can't remember, pick a day. Three: what cash will we have in two months? If you don't know, that's your answer. Four: who, or what, if gone tomorrow, would stop us? *Give two or three minutes. Ask one or two people what surprised them.*

23
CLOSE

Your brain has the ideas. Your heart decides whether they happen.

Message The line they repeat afterwards.

Goal End on the idea, not on admin.

> Your brain has the ideas. Your heart decides whether they happen. *Stop. Let it sit.* You'll always be the brain. The work is building a heart that doesn't need the brain to do its job as well.

24
NEXT

Where to go next: Operations Fundamentals. Start with OF101.

Message Tonight was the why. The course is the how.

Goal One clear next step.

> If tonight made sense, the course is where we build it. Operations Fundamentals starts with OF101: what operations is made of, panel by panel, and how to look at any decision from every side. *[Add how founders join.]*

Part 6 · Questions (15 minutes)

25
QUESTIONS

Questions.

Message Open floor.

Goal Hear which condition hit hardest; that's material for the next masterclass.

> What questions do you have? *If it's slow to start:* which of the four did you recognise most? *Note the answers; they tell you what the room needs next.*

4. Before the day

1. **Your four stories** (slides 10–13): one real, anonymised example per condition, with no client names and nothing that identifies a business. The fictional fallbacks work if you'd rather not.
2. **How founders join the course** (slide 24).
3. **A rehearsal against the clock.** Part 2 is where it overruns: five minutes per condition, including the story and the show of hands.

Reuse

Elevate LinkedIn Live, 30 minutes: parts 1, 2 and 5, with one story per condition and no live case. For an 18–30 audience, add that operations is where you learn how a business actually works. **Keynote, 20 minutes:** the picture, the four conditions, the four questions. **Carousel or article:** "Your business has a heart. Here are the four ways it fails."

Sources

These are the pages behind section 2. Some were seen only as search listings (see the caveat above).

- UCLA Anderson, The Founder Bottleneck: Scaling Without Burning Out · anderson.ucla.edu/alumni/event-details?eid=10013
- Operations Nation, Do I even need ops yet? · luma.com/doievenneedopsyet
- TUM Venture Labs, Scale Yourself to Scale Your Company · tum-venture-labs.de/events/scale-yourself-to-scale-your-company
- Indy Chamber, masterclass, March 2026 · indychamber.com/event/masterclass-march2026
- Schulich ExecEd, Masterclass Certificate in Venture Operations · execed.schulich.yorku.ca/program/schulich-masterclass-certificate-in-venture-operations
- Sirris, Scaleup Masterclass · sirris.be/en/agenda/scaleup-masterclass
- EOS Worldwide, Visionary vs Integrator · eosworldwide.com/visionary-vs-integrator
- The AI Edge Masterclass, London (Eventbrite) · eventbrite.com/e/the-ai-edge-masterclass-london-tickets-1989664515125
- Allison Pickens, Why operations is the core · allisonpickens.substack.com/p/podcast-why-operations-is-the-core

NexaStrategic · Draft. Fictional examples are labelled as such. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.